Legislative Role Models: Female Ministers and Parliamentary Debate

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Motivation

Barbara Castle

Betty Boothroyd

"Many years ago I worked in the House of Commons for a woman that I admired very much called Barbara Castle. She was my role model because I felt, well, if Barbara can do it then I can do it."

Research question

When women are promoted to high political office, do they serve as role models to other women in politics?

Related work

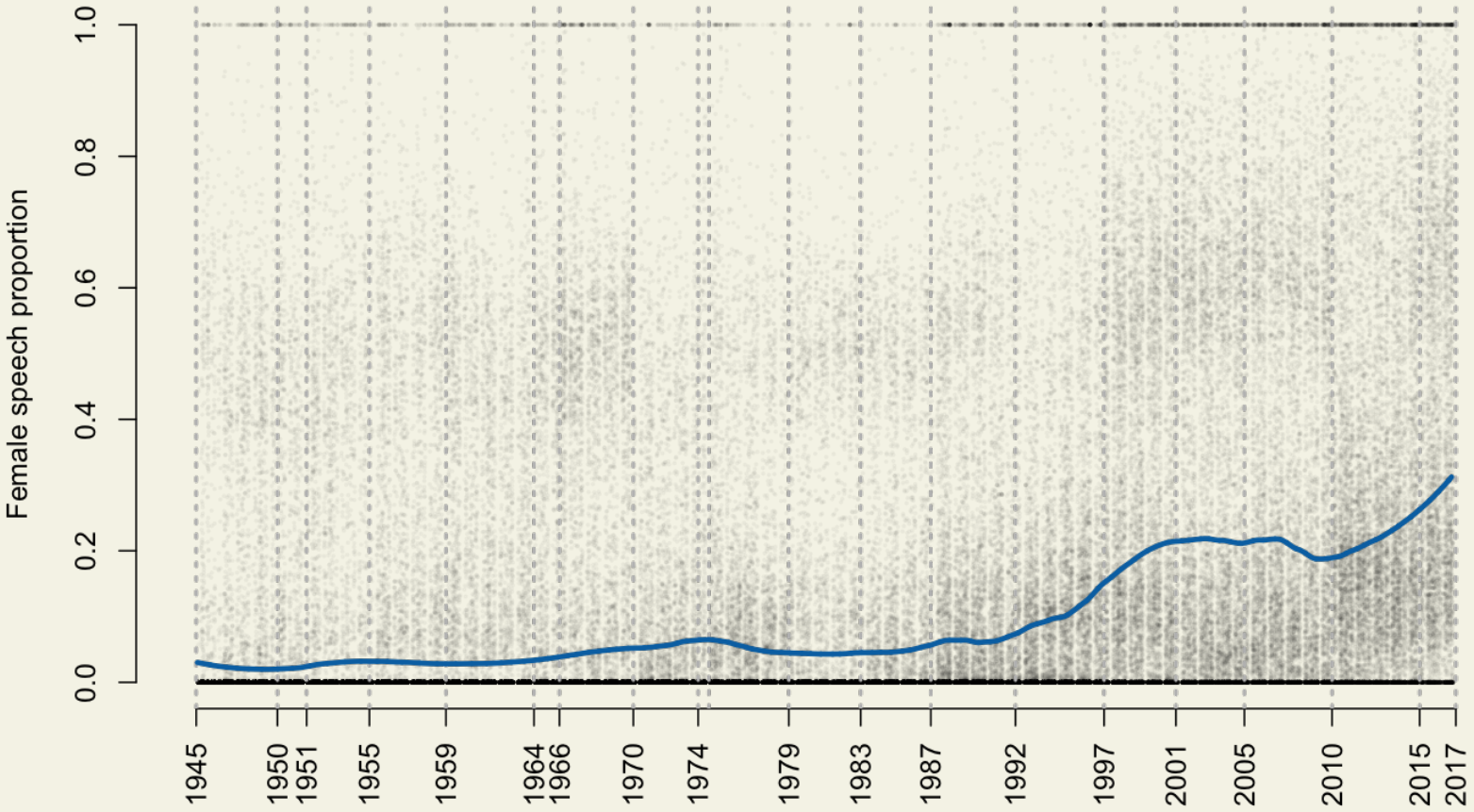
Female leaders have important motivating effects for other women:

- **Female teachers** $\rightarrow$ more female students take STEM subjects
- **Female CEOs** $\rightarrow$ more female promotions/decrease in gender wage gap
- **Female politicians** $\rightarrow$ other women more likely to participate in politics

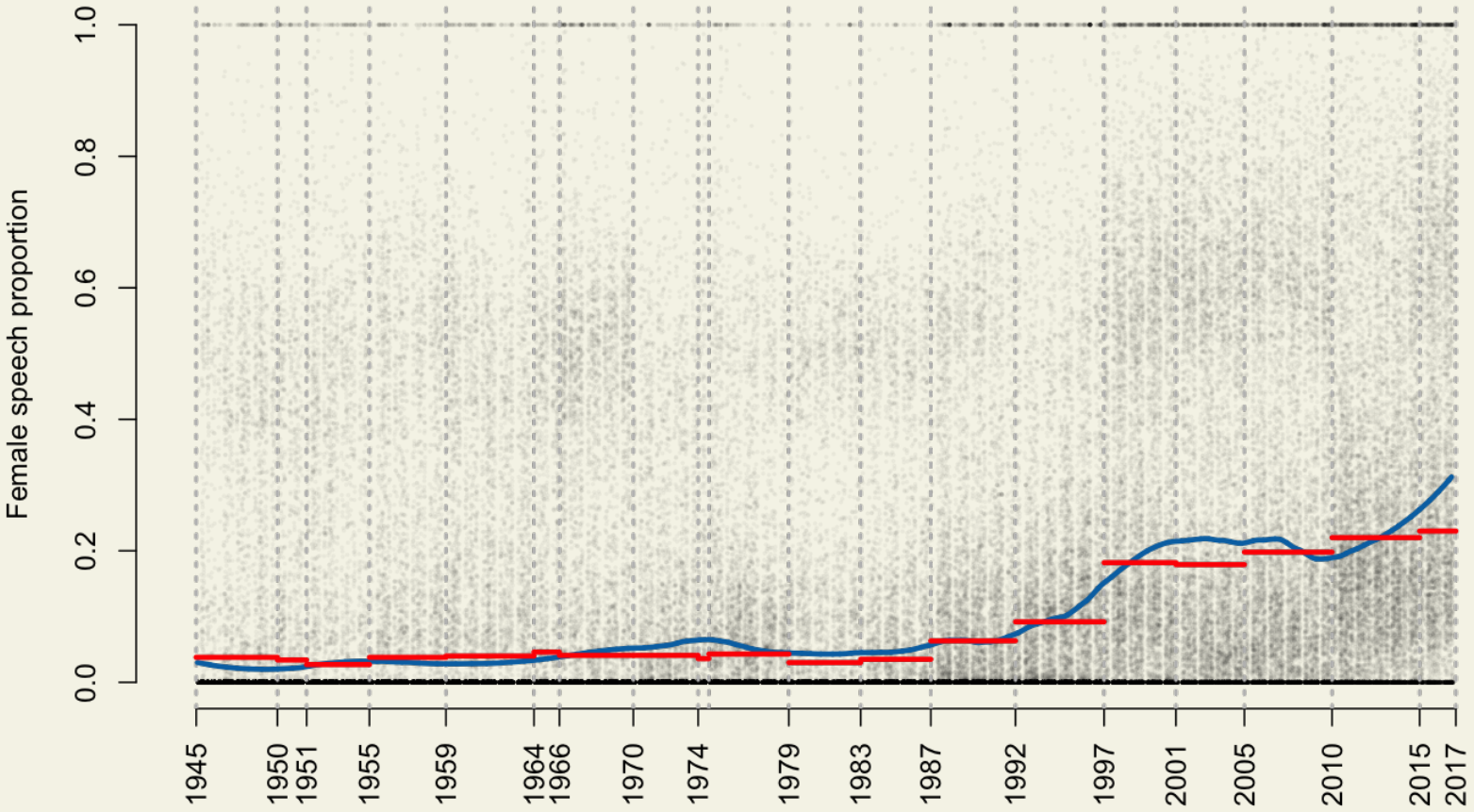
This project

- **Context:**
  - Female cabinet ministers in the House of Commons (1997 – 2017)
  - Experiences of other female MPs in parliamentary debate
    - Participation (How much do they speak?)
    - Influence (How much are they listened to?)
- **Data:**
  - Debate transcripts from the Commons (Hansard)
  - 15,000 debates
  - Half a million speeches
- **Results:**
  - Female ministers increase the **participation** of other female MPs
  - Female ministers increase the **influence** of other female MPs

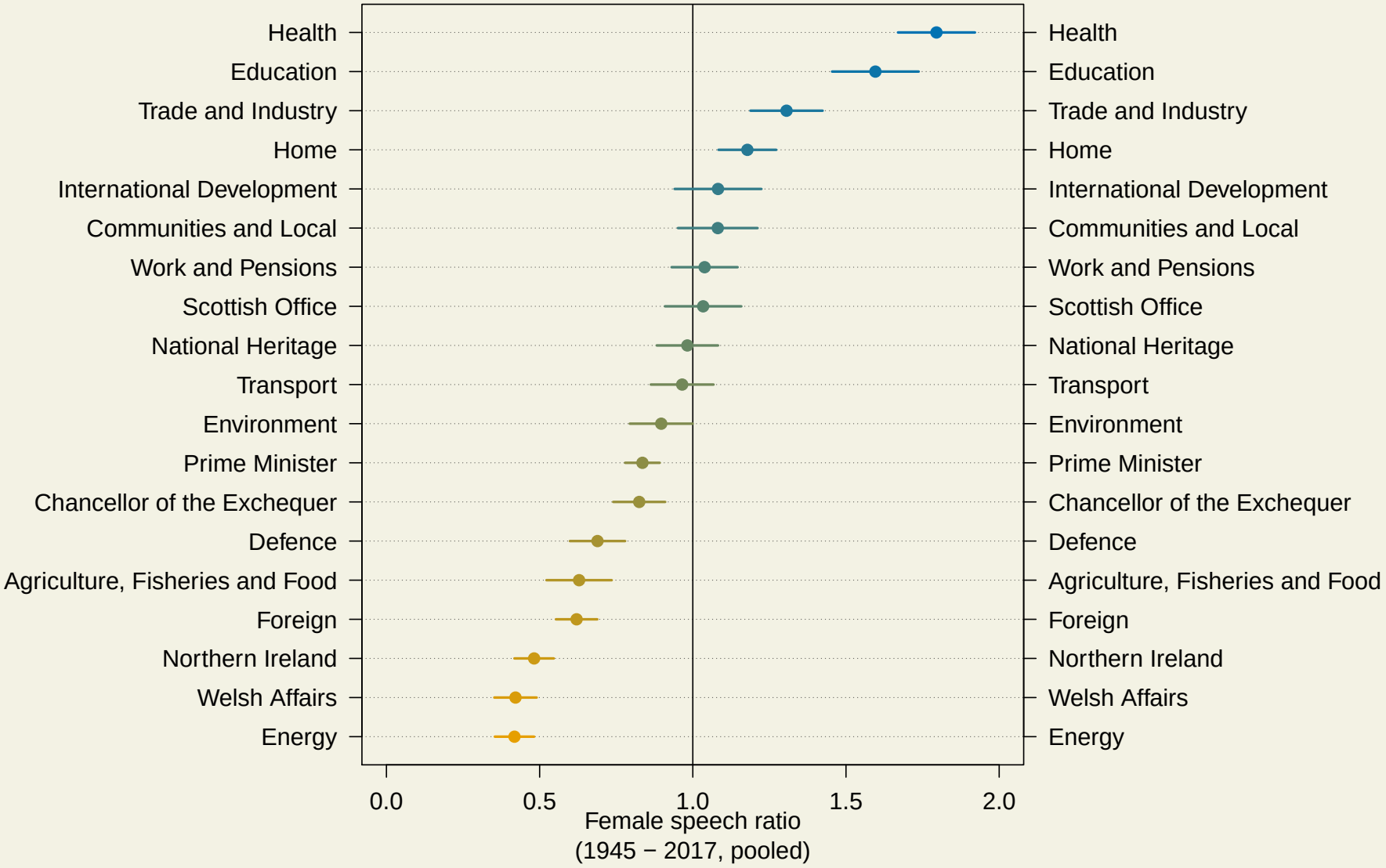
Female speech in the Commons



Female speech in the Commons



Female speech in the Commons

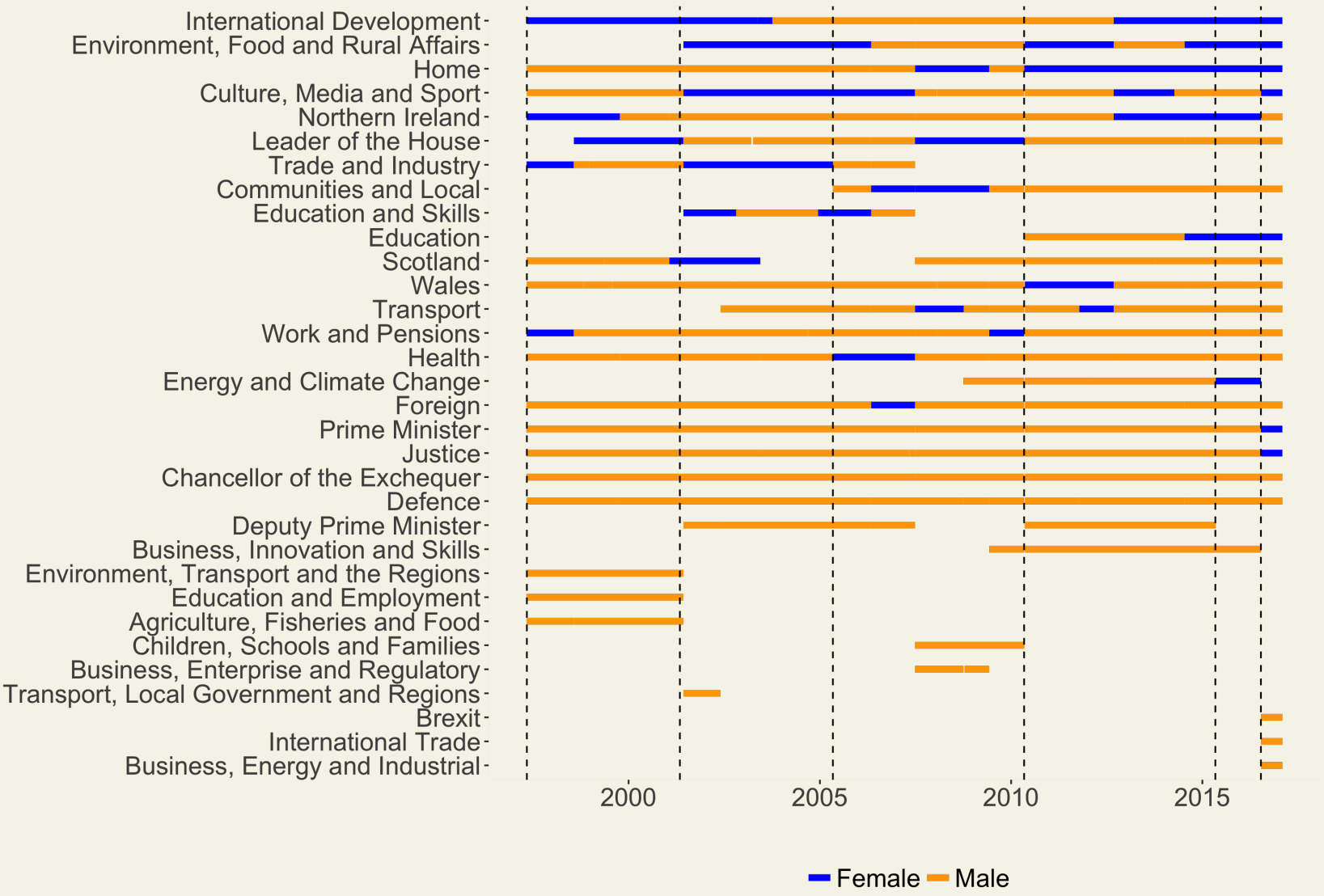


Participation

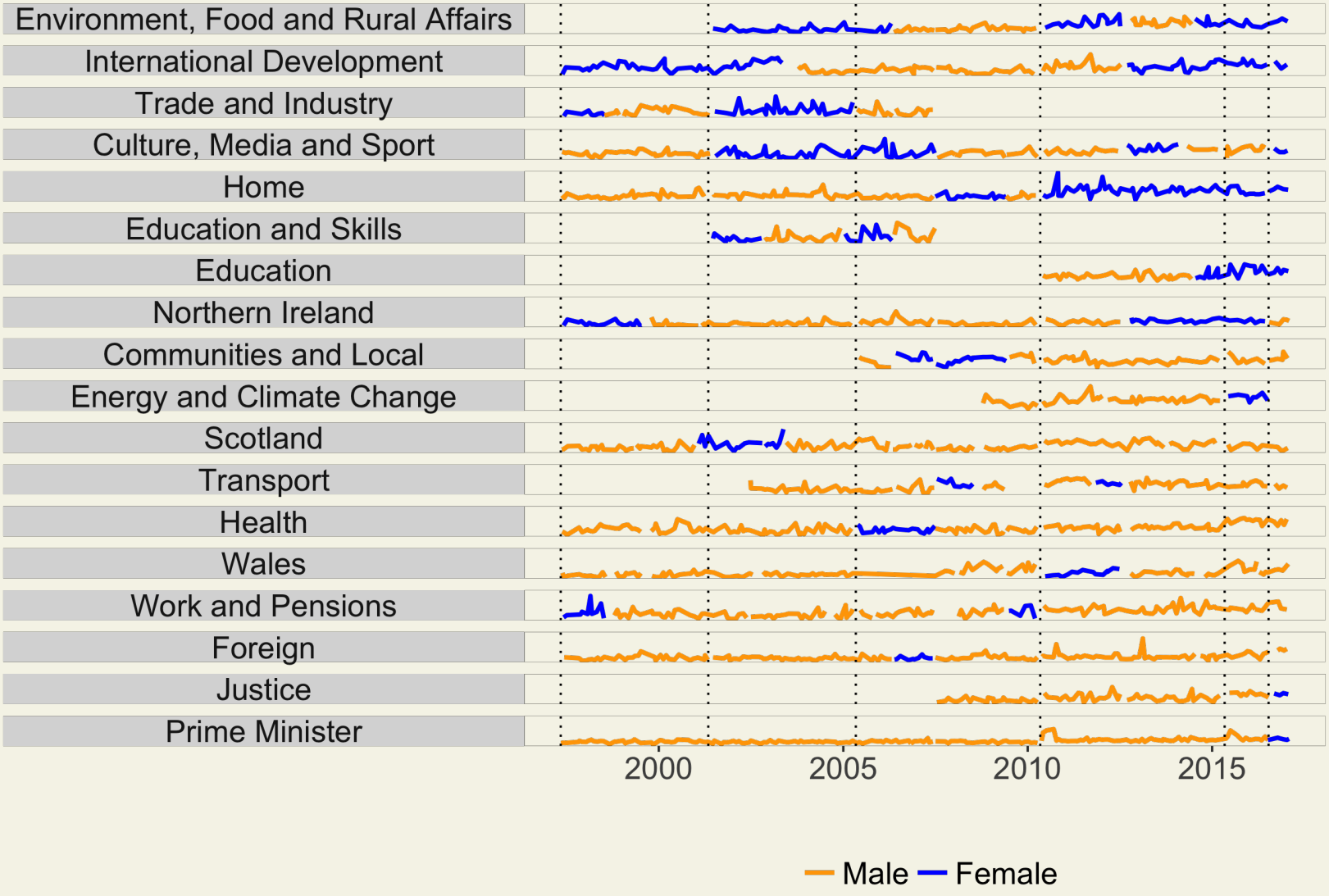
When women are appointed as cabinet ministers, do other women **participate more** in parliamentary debate?

- **Problem**: Misleading to simply compare debates with female/male ministers
  - Women are typically appointed to departments that deal with topics of particular interest to women
- **Solution**: Focus on changes of minister gender within departments
  - Hold topic of debate 'constant'

Female ministers over time



Participation results



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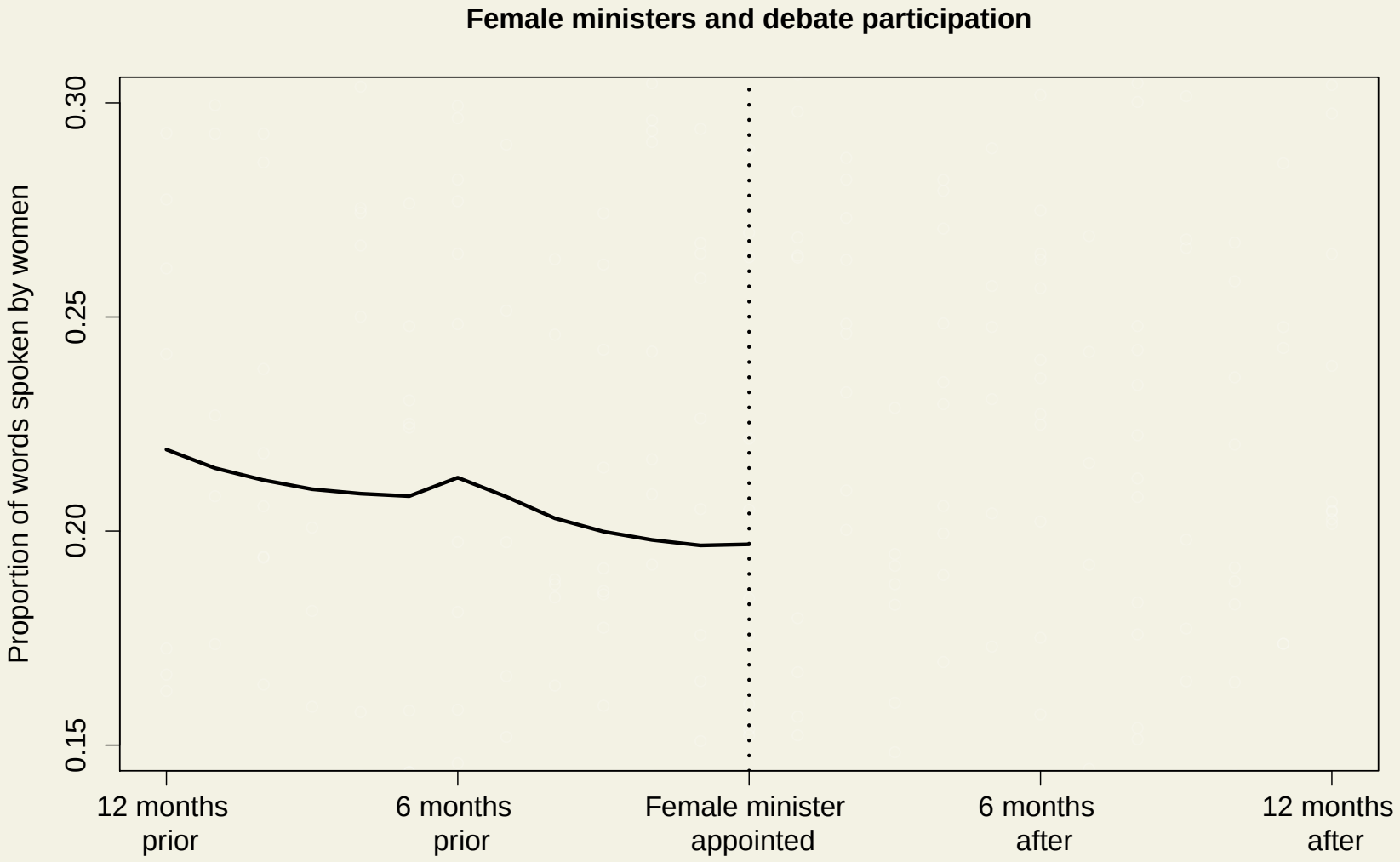

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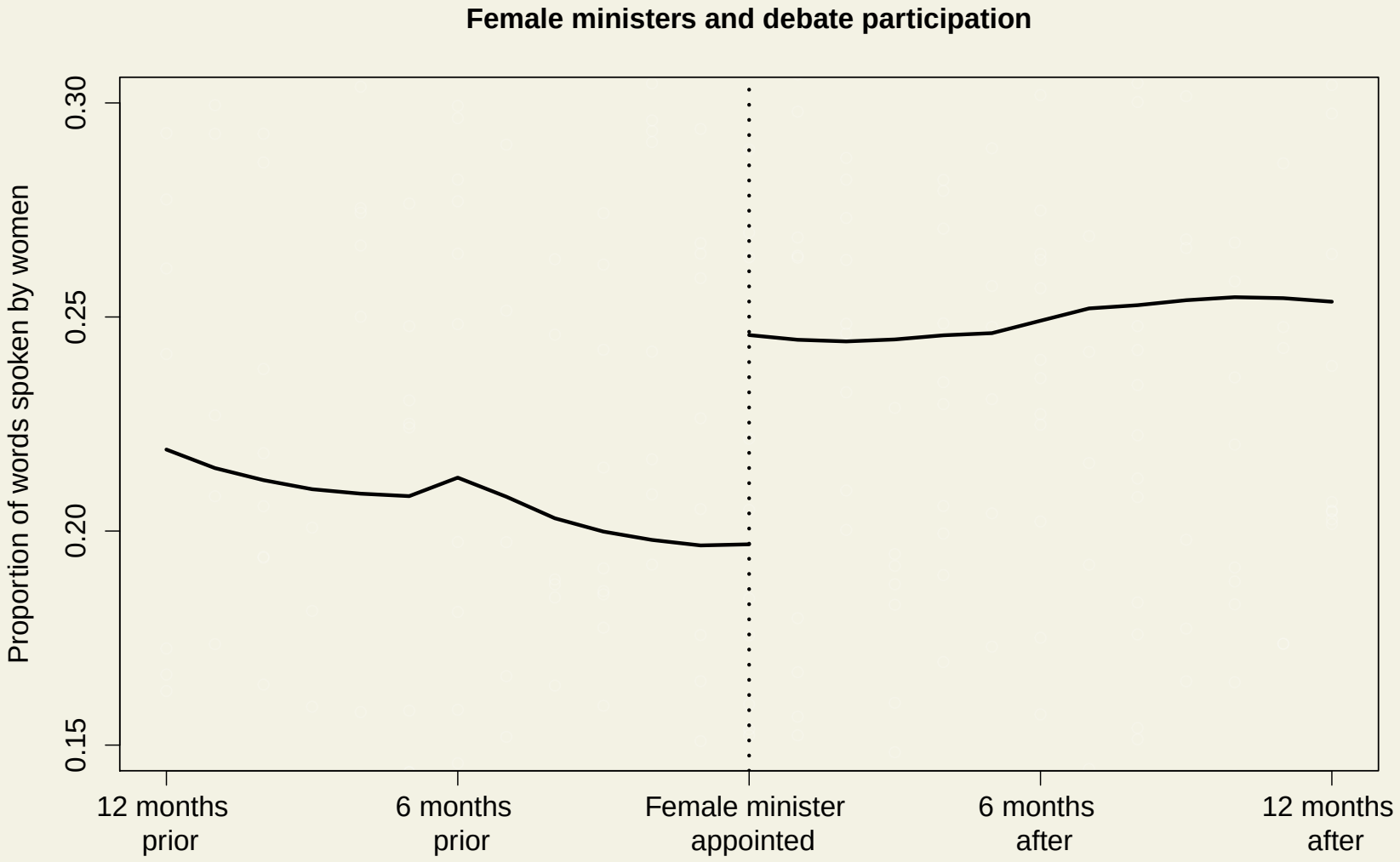

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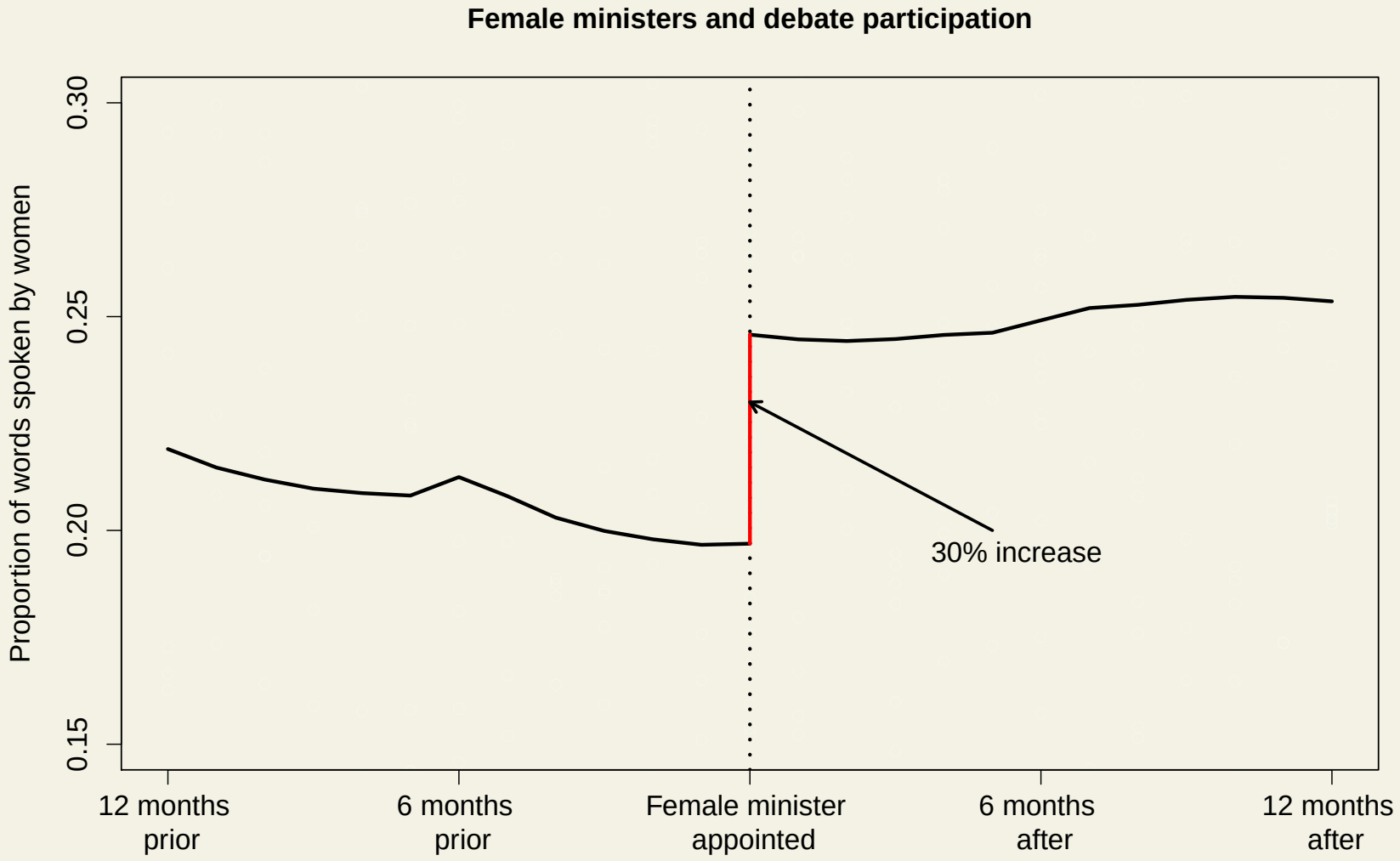

Influence

When women are appointed as cabinet ministers, do other women become **more influential** in parliamentary debate?

- **Problem**: How do we measure 'influence' in debate?
- **Assumption**: An MP is influential when the issues she raises in her speeches are adopted and discussed by other MPs
- **Strategy**: Evaluate which MPs' speeches are echoed by other speakers. The more this happens, the more influential the MP.

Main result: When a female minister is appointed, other women become $\approx 25\%$ more influential than under male ministers

Why do these effects occur?

1. Do female ministers focus on different policy issues?
    - No evidence that female ministers choose 'female-friendly' topics
2. Does the opposition strategically appoint female shadow ministers?
    - No evidence that opposition behave in this way
3. Do female ministers behave differently in debate?
    - Female ministers are more **responsive** to other women than men are

Discussion

Patricia Hewitt

Joan Ruddock

"It is a great pleasure, as it always is, to participate in a debate that is dominated by women. My right hon. Friend is a great role model for us not just in her role as Minister for Women, but also by being the head of a substantial Government Department."